

Moving with Pets

Relocating with pets requires careful planning to ensure their safety and comfort. Below, we have provided general information and guidelines to ensure a positive pet move. While many steps apply to all moves, international relocations involve additional requirements and timelines. Below are key recommendations for a successful move.

Health and Documentation

- **Domestic Moves:** Schedule a veterinary check-up and keep vaccination records accessible.
- **International Moves:** Most countries require a health certificate issued within 2–10 days of travel, endorsed by a government authority (e.g., USDA for U.S. exports). Additional requirements may include microchip registration, parasite treatments, and import permits. Confirm these well in advance.

Travel Crate and Acclimation

- Use an airline-approved crate sized according to your pet's measurements. Snub-nosed breeds and senior pets often require larger crates for airflow.
- Begin crate acclimation early; feed your pet inside the crate and allow them to rest in it to reduce stress.
- For international flights, crate sizing is stricter, and custom crates may be needed for large breeds.
- Please be prepared to remove your pet during airport security screening. These rules may vary by location (for example, in the U.S., the TSA requires pets to be removed from the crate during the screen).
- It is strongly recommended to review airline-specific requirements, as these can vary. This includes weight/size restrictions and other cabin rules (crate needs to fit under the seat, etc.).

Feeding and Hydration

- Feed pets no later than 2–4 hours before pickup to prevent stomach upset.
- Secure two water bowls inside the crate; freezing water can help minimize spills.
- Pets typically do not eat during travel. For international moves with comfort stops, attach a small bag of dry food and clear feeding instructions to the crate.

Comfort and Safety

- Include absorbent bedding and a familiar item (like an old t-shirt) for reassurance. Bedding must be less than 3 inches thick.
- Do not send toys, leashes, or bulky collars inside the crate. These are prohibited by most airlines.
- Sedation is not allowed for air travel. Instead, use crate training and calming aids such as pheromone sprays if needed.

Transportation and Check-In

- **Domestic:** Pets are checked in about two hours before departure. Ground transport should include frequent breaks for exercise and hydration.
- **International:** Check-in is typically four hours before departure. Some airlines offer comfort stops during layovers, allowing pets to walk, hydrate, and rest.

Arrival and Acclimation

- Maintain familiar routines for feeding, walking, and play. Keep old bedding and toys to provide comfort.
- Monitor for signs of stress (hiding, reduced appetite) versus illness (vomiting, fever). Contact a vet promptly if symptoms persist.
- Schedule a veterinary visit within a week of arrival. For international moves, confirm local licensing and vaccination requirements.
- Introduce new environments gradually and use positive reinforcement. For cats, calming pheromones can ease anxiety; for dogs, short training sessions and treats help build confidence.

Working with a Third-Party Pet Shipper

Why Use a Shipper? Professional pet relocation companies manage logistics, paperwork, and airline coordination, reducing stress and minimizing risk of delays.

- **Services Offered:** Flight booking, ground transportation, crate sizing, vet coordination, customs clearance, and real-time travel updates.
- **Employee Role:** Provide accurate pet details, keep original documents safe, and follow the shipper's timeline for vaccinations and paperwork.
- **International Advantage:** Shippers handle complex customs clearance, quarantine requirements, and country-specific regulations.